During a tour to India in 1996, we were due to play a benefit game for one of the Indian players – it would be the last game of the tour. The night before the game, Hansie got the whole team together and dropped a real bombshell. ‘I know a guy,’ he said, ‘who is going to give us US$250 000 if we lose this game.’

The offer was tempting, because we were probably going to lose the game anyway. We were well below strength, with six of our guys off sick – we were going to be on the back foot. I remember that I was fielding at point, which meant Jonty Rhodes wasn’t playing, and Gary Kirsten was wicketkeeper. That’s how bad it was.

Of course the team decided against taking the bribe, but, even so, it hadn’t been an immediate and strong reaction to an activity totally abhorrent to the notion of sport. Instead, we talked the offer over. Pat Symcox – always an oke willing to look at all sides of the equation – thought it was definitely worth *some* consideration. He wasn’t the only one. We decided that this was either something the whole team bought into or it was a no-go. Some of the guys, though, were dead against it, Andrew Hudson in particular. So that was that. We declined the offer. Sachin Tendulkar ended up getting a 100 in that game and, predictably, we lost.

Again, when Hansie came out with this second offer to chuck a game, I’d like to tell you that my first response was one of shock and horror, but again I’d be lying. The first thought that popped into my head was, ‘Well, my mom’s house needs to be paid off. I might as well try to make some money.’ The consequences of what Hansie was suggesting didn’t even enter my head. So I said, ‘Okay, cool.’

And just like that I made a decision that would get me into a world of trouble and that I would bitterly regret. It’s not like I agonised over the offer for days or had huge dollar signs in my eyes. Typically of me, I make spur-of-the-moment decisions, and sometimes these backfire. I genuinely didn’t give it too much thought, as it simply didn’t seem like that big a deal. I mean, we were down 1-3 in the five-match series, so it’s not like the game meant much either.

And besides, *Hansie* was doing the asking. And Hansie was one of the most together people I’d ever known. If he said throwing the match was cool, it was cool. Hansie then spoke to Henry, who said, ‘If Herschy says yes, I’ll go along with it too.’ The deal was that I would score fewer than 20